

SEEKING SUPPORT
BJP's Annamalai on the campaign trail in Coimbatore, Apr. 7

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**

FORMER INDIAN POLICE SERVICE officer Kuppuswamy Annamalai is just four years into his avatar as a politician but is already looking like a pro. At Palladam, on the outskirts of Coimbatore, the Lok Sabha constituency he is contesting from, bursting crackers and the beating of drums greet the arrival of his saffron mini-bus. Dressed in a white dhoti-kurta and sporting a craggy beard and hair, Annamalai steps on the hydraulic lift pedestal that enables him to pop up from the roof of the bus. Outside, party workers wave Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) flags furiously while cut-outs of Prime Minister Narendra Modi beam down from the poles that line the road.

Everything is carefully choreographed. Songs praising Modi's achievements and his vision for India blare out in Tamil as an ecstatic supporter thrusts a goat kid into the leader's arms for him to bless. Annamalai then picks up a microphone and talks to the crowd for some five minutes, exhorting them to vote for Modi and the BJP for "development". He never forgets to denounce the "dynastic trends and corruption" of the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) and its I.N.D.I.A. bloc partners. A little later, he stops at the house of a Dalit family to have lunch, which is served on a plantain leaf placed on the floor—just the right touch to assert his own rustic origins and belief in the equality of castes.

ANNAMALAI'S ABRASIVE NATURE WAS BLAMED FOR THE BREAK-UP WITH THE AIADMK, BUT HE SAYS "THEY WERE LOOKING FOR A REASON TO GET OUT..."

At 39, Annamalai is the youngest-ever president of the state BJP and also a one-man army who many feel could make a decisive difference to the party's electoral fortunes in the state. With a vote share of just 3.7 and 2.8 per cent in the previous Lok Sabha and assembly elections, respectively, the BJP, like the Congress, has always been forced to piggyback on alliances, either led by the DMK or its arch-rival, the All India Anna DMK (AIADMK). In the past two elections, the BJP went with the AIADMK and drew a blank in the Lok Sabha but won four seats in the assembly. With Annamalai at the helm this time, the BJP has decided to take a big gamble, and lead an alliance of its own with smaller caste-based parties.

The BJP state president's abrasive nature was blamed for precipitating the break-up with the AIADMK. The latter even said as much, but the real reason was that the alliance with the BJP was eroding the AIADMK's credibility and Dravida support base. Especially after the BJP's aggressive Hindutva push in the South and with Chief Minister M.K. Stalin of the DMK raising issues like fiscal federalism and the North-South divide. Annamalai, though, is quick to clarify, that he was not the prime mover behind the exit. "It wasn't like it was my decision alone or that I made an effort to break the alliance. It seemed like they (AIADMK) wanted to find a reason to get out of the alliance. Keep in mind that I am just the state president and decisions about alliances are decided at the national and parliamentary board levels," he says.

The BJP, though, has a larger game plan at work. With the AIADMK now weakened by the expulsion of the OPS (former deputy CM O. Panneerselvam) faction and no charismatic leader like the late J. Jayalalithaa to keep them together, the saffron party feels the Dravidian party may be